

Family Misfortunes

A coming-of-age tale of love and liberation that strings together pictures of suffering from the troubled life of an immigrant



IF YOU DON'T KNOW ME BY NOW: A MEMOIR OF LOVE, SECRETS AND LIES IN WOLVERHAMPTON
by SATHNAM SANGHERA
Penguin
Price: Rs 795; Pages: 336

■ By Geeta Doctor

It's as familiar a tale of Indian immigrant life in the UK as an *aloo paratha* served with tomato ketchup. Make that Sikh-Punjabi with all the attendant distractions such as weekly trips to the Gurudwara, troubles with a top-knot, platoons of relatives who drink and thrive in a process of reverse colonisation, and you have all the ingredients for several episodes of an Indian sitcom.

Sathnam Sanghera's coming of age tale of love and liberation from the ghetto of his family in the mean streets of Wolverhampton in the Midlands gets its energy from the very dismal quality of its beginnings. At the heart of it is a horrendous account of what it is to live with the mental breakdown of his father, whom we see first as sitting around the house in a passive stupor watching television. His mum is clattering pans in the kitchen. As Sanghera stands in the family living room, he records the scene with his trained journalist's eye: "All I could hear was a tape-recorder

murmuring prayers in the kitchen, and four plastic fish bopping around epileptically in the made-in-China 20-inch-tall aqua lamp placed on the phone stand. Opposite the lamp—probably a present from one of my market-trading relatives—hung a frame and a flashing picture of the Golden Temple, and at my feet lay a set of bathroom weighing scales and two ancient brown suitcases, a reminder of the reason for this particular visit home: my parents were heading off on one of their biennial trips to India."

SURVIVOR'S STORY: Sanghera unearths secrets about his parents

Hardly what one might call a moment of truth. Yet it is from the very ordinariness of such details that Sanghera creates the setting of his family history. He strips his family of their secrets as methodically as he inspects the contents of his parents' bags. The secret that he uncovers in painful detail has to do with the schizophrenic condition that has afflicted his father's life and will also claim the best part of his older sister's teenage years. He does not flinch at uncovering the violence that his mother experiences from the very first night of her marriage to a strange man in a strange land, nor does he allow himself to be obsessed by it. If at all there is anger, it is at the way Indian families deal with mental illness—by getting the person married and letting the partner handle the problem. Or if not that, someone has to take the blame for it, as his mother had to do.

It's a survivor's tale. He strings it along with a number of black and white pictures from the family album to the epiphany at the end in his London flat, where he brings his mum to show her what his adult life is really like. It could be a scene straight out of *Mother India*, but isn't, because his mum is much too down-to-earth for that kind of histrionics. Sanghera himself has imbibed enough of the English talent for a mocking self-knowledge so that he can play at being both Peter Sellers and Raj Kapoor. It is this dual identity of Indian ingénue and cool Cambridge educated voyeur that makes the book so enticing. ■



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